

See also: The Trade Union Act 156–159 ■ The Workers' Accident Insurance System 164–167 ■ The Representation of the People Act 188–189 ■ The Civil Rights Act 248–253 ■ *Roe v. Wade* 260–263 ■ Same-sex marriage 292–295

The Ford machinists' strike

On June 7, 1968, women sewing machinists at Ford's car factory in Dagenham, UK, went on strike. They were making the covers for the cars' seats, and without their contribution, the production line soon ground to a halt. Led by Rose Boland, Eileen Pullen, Vera Sime, Gwen Davis, and Sheila Douglass, the machinists were protesting against the grading of their jobs as Grade B (less skilled), which meant they got less pay than most of the men, who were put in Grade C (more skilled).

They argued that sewing demanded a very high level of skill and so they should receive equal pay.

The strike attracted a lot of attention, because the factory was important to the UK's economy, and women in other jobs also began to campaign for equality. Eventually, Barbara Castle, the secretary of state for employment and productivity, negotiated a pay rise for the machinists to within 8 percent of the men's wage. The Equal Pay Act was introduced 2 years later.



Leaders of the machinists' strike protest outside the offices of Barbara Castle. Three weeks later, Castle agreed to listen to their grievances.

flawed, and that the new legislation would discourage employers from hiring women. They also pointed out that Iceland had been top of the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Index—which monitors women's pay around the world—for 9 years out of the previous 10.

The idea that women and men should be paid equally is an old one. In 1839, French author George Sand described in her play *Gabriel* “an impenetrable crystal vault”—what later feminists would call the “glass ceiling,” the invisible barrier that stops women progressing as high in their careers as men.

Only after two world wars, when women had to take on jobs that had previously been done by men, were calls for equal pay widely heeded. In 1944, New York legislated that women should be paid the same as men for the same work, which also became a key principle of the new European Economic Community (EEC), founded in 1957.

The US introduced its first national legislation with the Equal Pay Act of 1963, and the UK followed

suit with its Equal Pay Act in 1970. Gradually, many other countries added their own laws.

Despite equal pay legislation, the gender pay gap—the average hourly percentage gap between the salaries received by men and women—has persisted. Women are paid on average just 77 percent of what men are paid. The reasons for this are complex. More women than

men work in lower-paid jobs, such as nursing or teaching, so their overall pay rate is lower. Typically male sectors, such as engineering, by contrast, pay well. Women also have less time to do paid work—they carry out 76.4 percent of domestic work and unpaid care globally. Even within companies, women tend to occupy roles that pay less—and very few women rise to the top of the pay scale. Iceland is one of the more equal countries in the world, yet even there, less than 20 percent of CEOs are women.

Long road ahead

Iceland's legislation may not remove the differences between men and women in career needs and aspiration, but it is a clear step toward righting inequality. Even so, pay (along with education, health, and political representation) is just one aspect of an overall global gender gap of 68.6 percent, which (based on the current rate of change across 153 countries) the World Economic Forum predicts will not close for 99.5 years. ■



In 99.6 percent of all occupations, men get paid more than women. That's not an accident; that's discrimination.

Elizabeth Warren
American politician and lawyer
(1949–)

